United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization

Intangible Cultural Heritage

# Safeguarding

## Unit 9 PowerPoint presentation

**UNESCO**
**Intangible Cultural Heritage Section**

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# In this presentation …

- Safeguarding defined and discussed
- Types of safeguarding measures
- Addressing threats and risks to viability
- Safeguarding plans



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# Safeguarding defined

- **Safeguarding** means ensuring the viability of ICH, while preserving its values (Article 2.3)
- **Safeguarding measures** are actions taken to promote ICH in general or to revitalize specific ICH elements (examples in Article 2.3)



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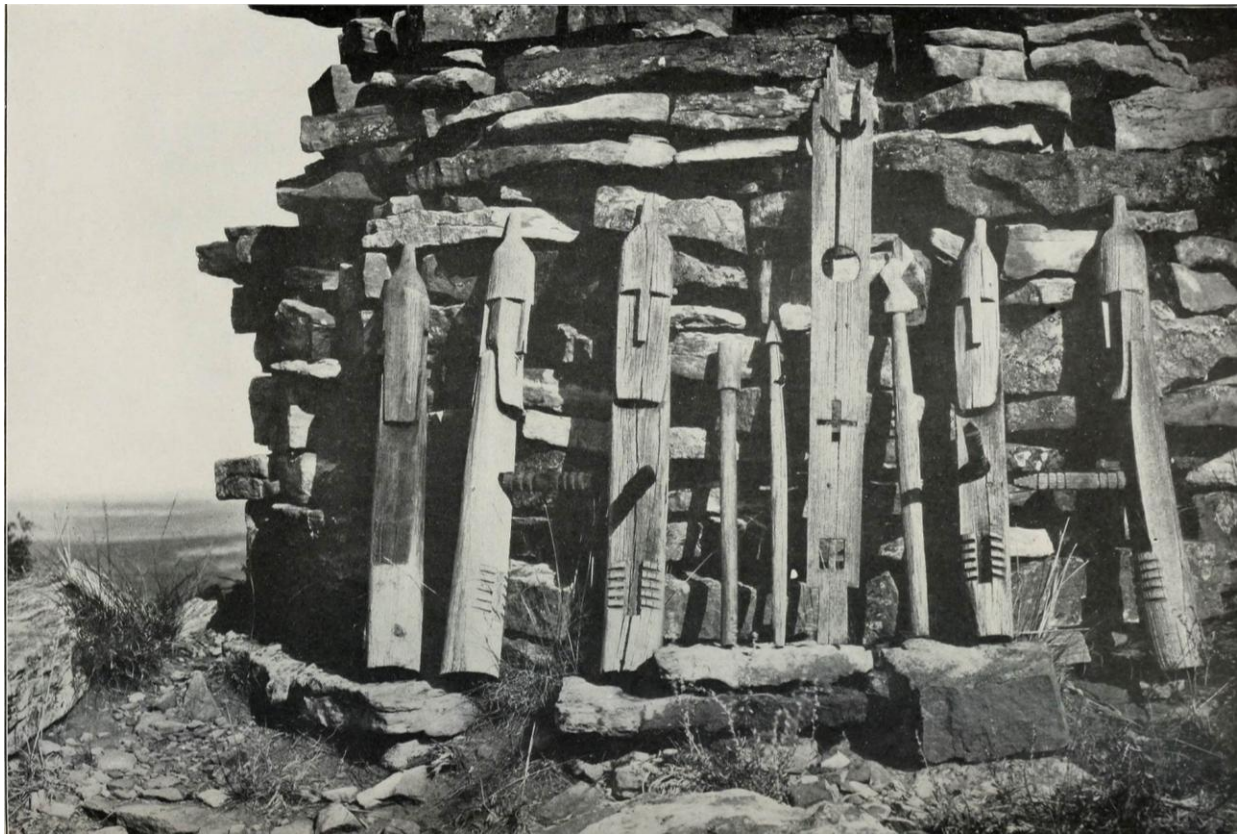
# Case study: the Ahayu:da war gods (USA) – safeguarding vs. conservation





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# The Convention and safeguarding

- States Parties shall '*take the necessary measures to ensure the safeguarding of the intangible cultural heritage present in [their] territory*' (Article 11(a))
- Article 17: Urgent Safeguarding List (USL)
- Article 18: Register of Good Safeguarding Practices (see also ODs 3–7 and 42–46)
- Priority assistance from the ICH Fund given to elements on the USL (Article 20; OD 9(a))



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# ‘The necessary measures’: do States need to safeguard all threatened ICH elements?

- Not all ICH elements can be safeguarded
- The Convention encourages both general measures aimed at creating favourable conditions for ICH, and specific measures aimed at safeguarding specific elements



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# General measures for safeguarding ICH

**Articles 11(b)–15 invite States Parties to:**

- Inventory the ICH
- Adopt legal, administrative and financial measures for safeguarding the ICH
- Raise awareness and foster respect for ICH
- Regulate the participation of communities in safeguarding activities and involve them in the management of their ICH



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# Measures for safeguarding specific ICH elements

With participation and consent of communities, groups and individuals:

- Identification
- Inventorying
- Documentation
- Research
- Revitalization
- Protecting related places and materials
- Encouraging transmission through education
- Awareness-raising

See Articles 2.3, 12, 13 and 14



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# Safeguarding of viable ICH elements

- Viable ICH elements may not require specific measures for safeguarding to ensure continued practice and transmission
- Continued practice and transmission may be encouraged through general measures



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# Addressing threats and risks

- Safeguarding measures address threats and/or risks to the viability of the ICH

See Articles 11(a) and 14(b); ODs 1, 2 and 7

Consider Ethical Principle 10.

# Voladores ceremony (Mexico)

© Cumbre Tajín, 2008

The ritual ceremony of the Voladores (‘flying men’) is a fertility dance performed by several ethnic groups in Mexico and Central America, especially the Totonac people in the eastern state of Veracruz, to express respect for and harmony with the natural and spiritual worlds.

# Threats to viability (1)

The flight of the Voladores around the pole is the climax of the ceremony.

Increasingly, only this part of the ceremony is performed, for tourists, outside the community context.

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# Threats to viability (2)

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Poles for the ceremony were traditionally cut down in the forest and ritually prepared.

Too few appropriate trees are now available, so people are using fixed metal poles.



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# Threats to viability (3)

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Ritual preparations for the ceremony help to maintain its significance for the community.

Performances by professional dancers reduce the focus on ritual aspects.



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# Voladores safeguarding measures

Meetings with Voladores groups; State and NGO support

Measures include:

- Reforestation
- Opportunities for performing the entire ceremony, including ritual dimensions
- Schools for Volador Children promoting the transmission of knowledge and skills, including ritual dimensions

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# Safeguarding with the communities concerned

- Ensure community participation (Article 15)
- Assess viability, threats and risks, respecting the Ethical Principles
- Assess commitments, opportunities and available funds
- Identify other partners
- Study previous interventions
- Develop a range of safeguarding measures and determine priorities
- Implement safeguarding measures
- Undertake monitoring and evaluation



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# Safeguarding plans

| *Activity* | *Stakeholders* | *Timetable* | *Cost/ Needs* | *Expected outcomes* |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | |



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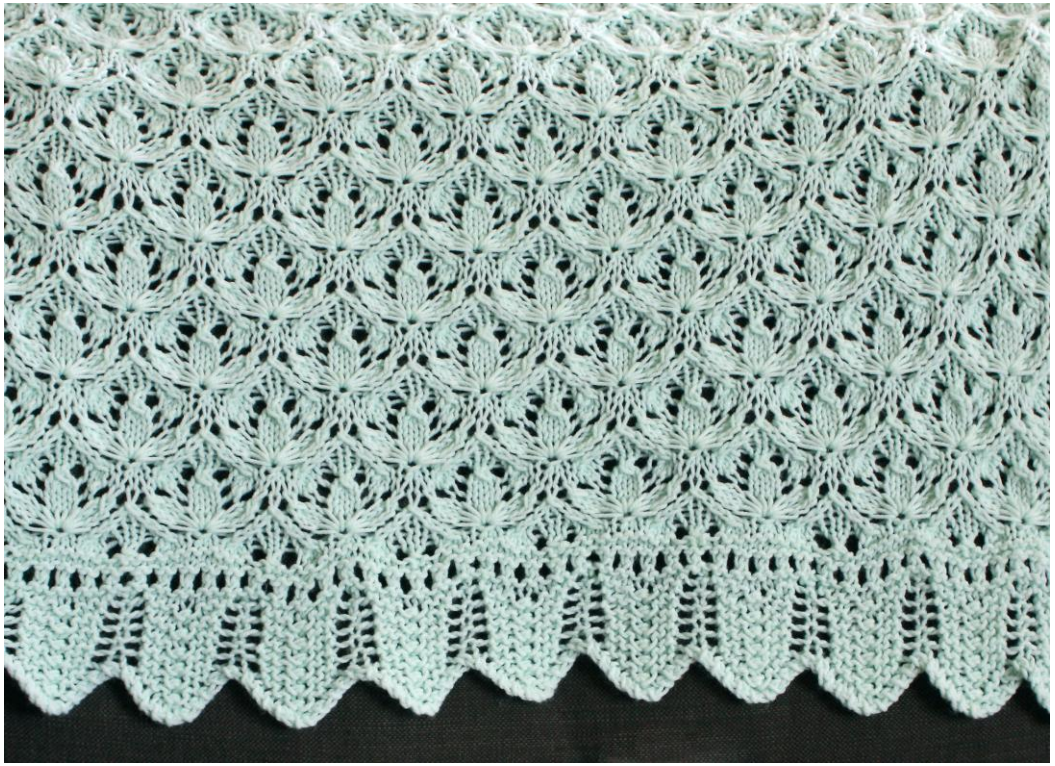
# Case study: Anu Raud's folk art centre (Estonia)





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# Case study: Gawad sa Manlilikha ng Bayan (GAMABA) system (the Philippines)

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# Case study: Sanbasomawashi ritual (Japan)

Sanbasomawashi is a votive art where two performers — a wooden doll puppeteer and a drummer — visit homes on New Year’s Day with Sanbaso and Ebisu wooden dolls in two wooden boxes.



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# Case study: Qiang New Year festival (China)

*Community members celebrating the festival*
© Wan Yuchan, 2005



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# Case study: Mongol Biyelgee (Mongolia)

© A. Duurenjargal, 2008

The Mongol Biyelgee – Mongolian Traditional Folk Dance is performed by dancers from different ethnic groups in the Khovd and Uvs provinces. Biyelgee dances embody and originate from the nomadic way of life.



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